Beijing on the twentieth anniversary of the founding of the People's Republic.[26]

There were some signs of reciprocity—what Haksar called "slight changes."[27] In spring 1969, the Chinese deputy premier unusually did not mention India—or the US—in a speech at a Pakistani reception in Beijing. Gandhi told Soviet premier Alexei Kosygin when he visited in May that the Chinese chargé had started attending official functions in Delhi.[28] With China still in the throes of the Cultural Revolution, however, the Chinese response was limited. Haksar expressed frustration that Indian overtures only seemed to be met with "rebuff and discourtesy." In this context, it was difficult to determine whether even the small signs of a change in Beijing's attitude toward India "mean[t] anything."[29]

Uncertainty meant that Indian policymakers remained concerned about the external threat from China. Given the state of Indian defenses, Gandhi believed even a "limited engagement" with China would be "quite serious."[30] Policymakers watched closely Beijing's attitude toward Delhi, as well as toward Moscow and Washington. China hands in India saw as a bad sign the Chinese cancellation in February 1969 of talks with the US in Warsaw and the Sino-Soviet Ussuri River clashes in March.[31] In the aftermath of more Sino-Soviet skirmishes in August, Gandhi was additionally anxious about Chinese troop movements in Tibet and Xinjiang, concerned that "having failed to make any impression on the Soviet Union, the Chinese might turn their thoughts towards our country and may find in Pakistan a ready response."[32]

While Nixon was plotting a potential path to Beijing through Islamabad, in Delhi there was persistent anxiety about China plotting with Pakistan against India. The ongoing Sino-Pakistan construction and operation of a road linking Xinjiang and Pakistan-held Kashmir exacerbated these concerns. Indian officials saw this as part of a Chinese encirclement effort. The reported establishment of a Sino-Pakistan bureau to coordinate training, financing, and arms supply to various insurgent groups in India's northeast would have done nothing to alleviate Delhi's concerns.[33]

Delhi remained worried about the internal threat from China, especially given the turmoil in India's northeast. Gandhi conveyed her concern to Rogers about Chinese support for "hostile tribes with arms and training."[34] The arrest in India of Naga guerrillas trained in China highlighted Beijing's